



APPS



Jack Dorsey's Bluetooth
messaging app Bitchat
now on App Store



[Bitchat](#), a messaging app created by Twitter and Block founder Jack Dorsey, is available to download from the [iOS App Store](#). Dorsey says he coded the basis of the app over the course of a weekend in early July.

Bitchat operates through Bluetooth mesh networks, which means that users can send messages to others within the range of Bluetooth connectivity — usually around 100 meters — without cell reception or a Wi-Fi connection.

The app's UX is very minimal. There is no log-in system, and you're immediately brought to an instant messaging box, where you can see what nearby users are saying (if anyone is actually around you and using the app) and set your display name, which can be changed at any time.

While Bitchat is sparking interest due to Dorsey's reputation, the concept of Bluetooth-powered messaging apps is not new. These apps are also popular in settings like large music festivals, where cell service may be limited, or in the aftermath of natural disasters, where cell service and Wi-Fi availability may be impacted. The Bluetooth messaging app [Bridgefy](#) was notably used during pro-democracy [protests](#) in Hong Kong, since its ability to function without the internet made it harder for authorities to detect.

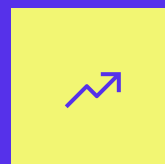
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Dorsey advertised Bitchat as a secure, private messaging platform when it went live for beta use earlier this month. But security researcher Alex Radocea [pointed out in a blog post](#) that it's easy to impersonate other people within Bitchat, calling into question how secure the "[vibe-coded](#)" app really is.

"In cryptography, details matter," Radocea wrote. "A protocol that has the right vibes can have fundamental substance flaws that compromise everything it claims to protect."

Dorsey later admitted that the software had [not been subject to an external security review](#) and thus may contain vulnerabilities.

Bitchat's concerns around impersonation also extend to the app itself. As of now, the app can be downloaded for iOS via the App Store, or it can be loaded onto an Android device by [downloading the app from GitHub](#). However, the Google Play store hosts multiple apps that appear to be pretending to be Dorsey's app, which have garnered thousands of downloads.

Dorsey has not directly addressed the fake Bitchat apps on the Google Play store, but he did repost [another user's X post](#) that said that Bitchat is not yet on Google Play, and to "beware of fakes."

Topics: [Apps](#) [Bitchat](#) [jack dorsey](#)

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Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She...

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IMAGE CREDITS:

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SECURITY



Jack Dorsey says his ‘secure’ new Bitchat app has not been tested for security

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 11:37 AM PDT · July 9, 2025

On Sunday, Block CEO and Twitter co-founder Jack Dorsey [launched an open source chat app called Bitchat](#), [promising](#) to deliver “secure” and “private” messaging without a centralized infrastructure.

The app relies on Bluetooth and end-to-end encryption, unlike traditional messaging apps that rely on the internet. By being decentralized, Bitchat has potential for being a secure app in high-risk

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environments where the internet is monitored or inaccessible. According to Dorsey’s [white paper](#) detailing the app’s protocols and privacy mechanisms, Bitchat’s system design “prioritizes” security.

But the claims that the app is secure, however, are already facing scrutiny by security researchers, given that the app and its code have not been reviewed or tested for security issues at all — by Dorsey’s own admission.

Since launching, Dorsey has [added a warning](#) to Bitchat’s GitHub page: “This software has not received external security review and may contain vulnerabilities and does not necessarily meet its stated security goals. Do not use it for production use, and do not rely on its security whatsoever until it has been reviewed.”

This warning now also appears on Bitchat’s main GitHub project page but was not there at the time the app debuted.

As of Wednesday, Dorsey [added](#): “Work in progress,” next to the warning on GitHub.

This latest disclaimer came after security researcher Alex Radocea found that it’s possible to impersonate someone else and trick a person’s contacts into thinking they are talking to the legitimate contact, [as the researcher explained in a blog post](#).

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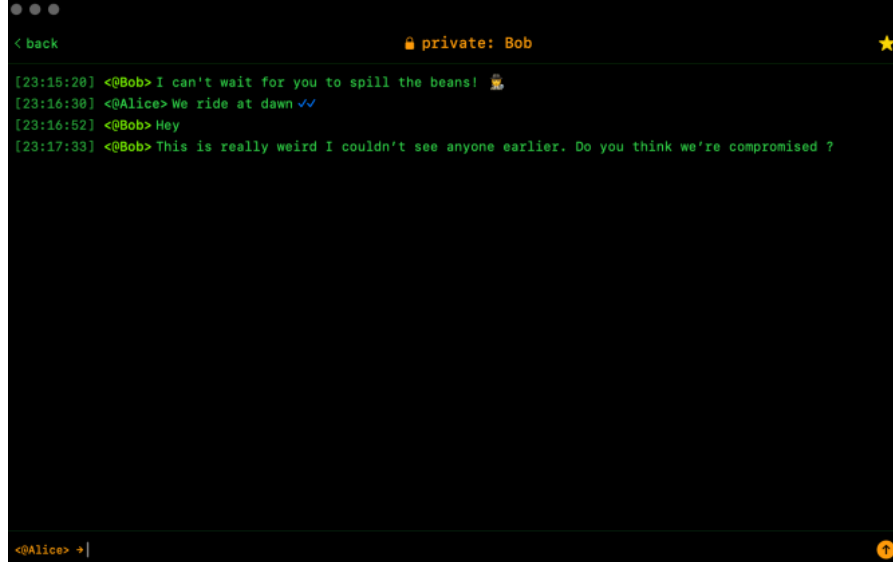
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Radocea wrote that Bitchat has a “broken identity authentication/verification” system that allows an attacker to intercept someone’s “identity key” and “peer id pair” — essentially a digital handshake that is supposed to establish a trusted connection between two people using the app. Bitchat calls these “Favorite” contacts and marks them with a star icon. The goal of this feature is to allow two Bitchat users to interact, knowing that they are talking to the same person they talked to before.

Dorsey did not respond to TechCrunch’s request for comment sent to his Block email address.



A SCREENSHOT SHOWING AN EXAMPLE OF A CHAT WHERE AN ATTACKER HAS IMPERSONATED “BOB” IN A CHAT WITH “ALICE,” WHICH BITCHAT MADE IT SEEM LIKE IT WAS REALLY COMING FROM BOB.

IMAGE CREDITS:ALEX RADOCEA

On Monday, Radocea filed a ticket on the GitHub project to ask how to report the security flaw he discovered in the Bitchat Favorites system. Soon after, Dorsey marked it as “completed,” without comment. ([Dorsey reopened the ticket](#) on Wednesday, saying security issues can be reported by posting on GitHub directly.)

Another person [reported](#) concerns with Dorsey’s claims that Bitchat has “forward secrecy,” a cryptographic technique that ensures that even if an attacker steals or compromises an encryption key, that attacker still cannot decrypt previously sent messages.

Someone also [pointed out](#) a potential buffer overflow bug, which is a common type of security vulnerability where a hacker can force a device’s memory to spill out to other locations, opening the door for a data compromise.

Radocea warned that Bitchat users should not trust the app yet.

“Security is a great feature to have for going viral. But a basic sanity check, like, do the identity keys actually do any cryptography, would be a very

obvious thing to test when building something like this,” Radocea told TechCrunch. “There are people out there that would take the messaging around security literally and could rely on it for their safety, so the project in its current state could endanger them.”

Referring to his and other people’s findings, Radocea criticized Dorsey’s warning that Bitchat has not been tested for security.

“I’d argue it has received external security review, and it’s not looking good,” he said.

Topics: [Bitchat](#) [e2e encryption](#) [encryption](#)

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Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

Senior Reporter, Cybersecurity |

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai is a Senior Writer at TechCrunch, where he covers hacking, cybersecurity,...

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APPS





Decentralized social networking app Damus to be removed from App Store, will appeal decision

Aisha Malik — 2:44 PM PDT · June 26, 2023

Damus, a [decentralized social networking app](#) backed by Twitter co-founder Jack Dorsey, will be removed from the App Store due to Apple's strict payment rules. Apple had threatened to remove Damus earlier this month over the app's tips feature, claiming that it could be used by content

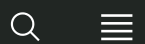
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clear that no digital content is getting unlocked when users are tipped. Users are only ever tipped after posts are made, the idea that content is being

sold is nonsense. We will be filing...

pic.twitter.com/Su945kE37v

— Damus ⚡ (@damusapp) [June 26, 2023](#)

Despite the changes, Damus revealed on Monday that its app will be removed from the App Store. The company shared a screenshot of Apple’s review notes, which state that the app’s tips feature still does not comply with its guidelines. The tech giant wrote that “although tips or donations may be optional, if they are connected to or associated with receiving digital content, they must use in-app purchase in accordance” with its guidelines.

A spokesperson for Apple told TechCrunch in an email that the company rejected the app upon receiving Damus’ latest submission, noting that the issues it had previously outlined were unresolved.

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Damus plans to file an appeal to fight Apple's decision.

"Looks like we are getting removed from the App Store even after updating our app to make it clear that no digital content is getting unlocked when users are tipped," Damus wrote in [a tweet](#). "Users are only ever tipped after posts are made, the idea that content is being sold is nonsense. We will be filing an appeal as this guideline is clearly being abused and misapplied."

Last year, Twitter co-founder Jack Dorsey donated around \$245,000 in bitcoin (then roughly 14 BTC) to fund the development of an open and decentralized social networking protocol known as Nostr, which is based on cryptographic key pairs. Damus is the first mobile app to leverage the protocol. Dorsey reacted to Apple's decision in a tweet on Monday, outlining [that "tips aren't unlocking content."](#)

Tips aren't unlocking content, [@Apple](#)
<https://t.co/4OFHMml7tm>

— jack (@jack) [June 26, 2023](#)

Damus hit the App Store in February and was one of many Twitter rivals to emerge following Elon Musk's takeover of the social network, which had driven Twitter users to try out decentralized social networking services, like Mastodon. Damus has seen approximately 255,000 downloads globally on iOS since its release, according to mobile analytics firm data.ai.

The app's promise is an open social network without a central authority that makes decisions about the network's content or who's allowed to participate, as Facebook or Twitter do. Damus has end-to-end encrypted messaging and does not require users to sign up with a phone number, email, or name because of how the Nostr works.

It's worth noting that this isn't the first time that Damus has run into issues with Apple. Damus faced some issues when going through the app review process due to its decentralized nature, as Apple had kept asking the app to follow the same rules as any other social network, such as providing a way for users to flag objectionable content and having a policy that makes it clear that abuse is not allowed.

The company previously said the app had [been rejected repeatedly](#), despite making changes to adhere to the tech giant's guidelines. That changed in February, when the app was finally approved.

Damus, another decentralized social networking app, arrives to take on Twitter



Another decentralized social networking application to challenge Twitter has hit the App Store. Last year, Twitter co-founder Jack Dorsey donated around \$245,000 in bitcoin (then roughly 14 BTC) to fund the development of an open

and decentralized social networking protocol known as Nostr, which is based on cryptographic key pairs. Now, the first

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Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter | [X](#)

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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Verizon's new 'Safe Wi-Fi' is a VPN that blocks ad tracking for \$3.99 a month

Kirsten Korosec — 12:34 PM PDT · July 28, 2018

IMAGE CREDITS: DAVID RAMOS / GETTY IMAGES

Verizon has rolled out a new product called Safe Wi-Fi, a VPN that provides a security stop gap for its

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mobile customers logging onto a public network. It's also being marketed as a way to block ads.

So [WTF is a VPN](#) and why does it matter? A VPN is a virtual private network. It sits between a device in front of you and a server in a data center. Think of it as a tunnel that cloaks or hides your internet traffic from other folks on your local network. That open Wi-Fi at your local coffee shop can give advertisers and more nefarious types the ability to track your IP address. A VPN provides a secure connection between you and the server, and hides the IP address from prying eyes.

Safe Wi-Fi (check out the video below) costs \$3.99 a month per account and is available to Verizon customers on Android and iOS. Safe Wi-Fi covers up to 10 devices on a single account.

Verizon customers can sign into My Verizon and go to the [Products & Apps](#) page, scroll to Safe Wi-Fi and then click "get it now" to subscribe. The Safe Wi-Fi feature is then added to their account.

Customers can download the Safe Wi-Fi app from the Google Play Store or Apple App Store on their device and then follow the onscreen instruction to sign up with a one-month free promotion.

Users can turn on the "Ad Tracker Blocker" within the Safe Wi-Fi settings. The Ad Tracker Blocker prevents customers from ad network tracking while browsing the internet, and from ads generated from the device's downloaded apps, according to [Verizon's FAQ page](#) on the feature. In some cases, ads will be blocked entirely to prevent ad trackers from working. A gray image will replace the ad on the screen, Verizon says.

Websites that require ad trackers may be blocked, according to the company.

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It's important to remember that a VPN doesn't eliminate the risk entirely. As TechCrunch reporter Romain Dillet notes, the [risk just moves down the VPN tunnel](#). The person operating the server can see all unencrypted traffic. VPN companies might examine a customer's browsing habit and sell them to advertisers, for example.

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Update: Verizon's notes in its FAQs that it does not monitor customers' internet browsing history.

Disclosure: Verizon owns TechCrunch parent company Oath.



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